

The only option would be to enroll in another school for the summer and get credit there to transfer to Emerson. Emerson would likely reject the credits, but Viacom could feel good knowing it was technically “paying” me, and Emerson could feel good that the internship was benefiting my education. I could enroll for the summer at South Florida’s Broward Community College and transfer the credits to Emerson in the fall. I’d be paying BCC money to attend for the summer classes that were my internship. Viacom benefited from my free work, and Broward Community College benefited from my tuition dollars when I wasn’t actually a student. It wasn’t just an unpaid internship; it was an internship I was paying for.

This is not an uncommon plight. *Inside Higher Ed* published a story in May 2016 about students who *pay* to take unpaid internships and the other unexpected costs of requiring students to take academic internships to graduate. I luckily didn’t need an internship other than the *Globe* to graduate, but some programs would have left me no choice.

I eventually accepted the position with *The Daily Show* and had two weeks to search for a suitable person to sublet my Allston apartment and a new place in NYC. A friend took my room in Boston for the summer, and I found a room through Craigslist in Brooklyn, in the Greenpoint neighborhood, where it would take me an hour to get into the city. The rent was \$900. I had no idea how I was going to make it through the summer, but I started the internship on my 21st birthday with \$2,700 of rent weighing on my shoulders.

In Boston, I was used to working long hours, but with the bright light of a paycheck at the end of the week’s tunnel. This was not the case now. College credit wasn’t going to pay for my MetroCards or my lunches.

My new place in Brooklyn didn’t have a bed frame or any furniture in it, but I didn’t have the means to furnish it, so my mattress remained on the floor. My clothes were folded in my suitcase as I’d brought them. Every day for lunch, I went to a bodega and bought a salad buffet and then tried to fill it with as much protein or veggies as I could. A favorite trick was to hide hard-boiled eggs under the lettuce and hope the cashier wouldn’t charge me for them.

Spending money is an expected part of living in New York City, but of course there’s no travel or clothing stipend given during most unpaid internships. You